Cup, Rohit Sharma was candid enough to accept that it did play a role in India's extended dry run at ICC trophies. There was a realisation that not replicating your A-game on crunch days was a problem that needed to be tackled head-on. India needed a new T20 blueprint.

THE T20 'TOTAL CRICKET'

The plan was simple—India had to play new-age T20 cricket. Indian cricket found itself in a conundrum similar to what was expressed memorably by the late Dutch footballing genius, Johan Cruyff: "Playing football is very simple, but playing simple football is the hardest thing there is." The idea of adapting to the new demands of T20 cricket—batting with intent and aggression no matter how many wickets down—wasn't new. "We want to keep playing our natural attacking game even if we are 30 for 3," Rohit Sharma had said after India's first-round exit at the 2022 Asia Cup in UAE. Yet, come the big occasion, and India sought refuge in the comfort of percentage cricket—a template they had pioneered during the 2013 Champions Trophy, and which served them well for years. The onus there would be on the top three—Rohit, Shikhar Dhawan and Virat mostly—to mix caution with aggression and take India to a healthy total whilst consuming the bulk of the overs.

But, like everything else, this too had a sell-by date, especially in T20 cricket, where the rest of the world had moved on to the 'throw caution to the wind' approach. And even though India's trademark template continued paying dividends in the one-day format, in T20s, it became dated quicker than a Suryakumar Yadav half-century. And much like Cruyff's revolutionary concept of 'total football', Indian cricket needed 'total cricket'.

Cruyff's 'total football' challenged the age-old football conventions—that defenders are there to save goals, midfielders to feed the attackers and strikers to score goals. Breaking down silos and espousing fluidity and inter-changing roles, total football maximised the utility of all 11 players, both while attacking and defending. It thus made it difficult for the opposition to plan against a team where players execute multiple functions. The Dutch maestro's idea also encouraged the concept that attack is the best form of defence—teams under him would look to score even when leading by a healthy margin, where other teams would safely park the bus. When extrapolated to cricket, Cruyff's approach would expect teams to a) field plenty of multi-dimensional players, and b) bat with aggression, irrespective of how the wickets column read.

The past few years saw T20 cricket go through a similar transformation, with most top teams such as Australia, England and West Indies quickly adapting to it. India, on the other hand, was imprisoned by its old, dry-as-dust strategy. For the winners of the inaugural edition of the T20 World Cup, playing total cricket would need a 360-degree change in approach. For starters, Indian cricket needed to free itself from the 'star player' phenomena. The focus had to shift towards runs in front of the team's name rather than obsess over runs in front of a player's name. And that's when the two biggest names in the Indian team, evidently, put their hands up.

SOMETHING AKIN TO CRUYFF'S TOTAL FOOTBALL IS NOW THE WINNING T20 APPROACH. LAGGARDS FOR LONG, INDIA FINALLY ADOPTED THIS TEMPLATE IN THE WORLD CUP

GREATER THAN THE SUM OF ITS PARTS

A leader must lead from the front—as clichéd as it sounds, its effectiveness cannot be overstated. When you expect the entire team to keep attacking irrespective of what it does to their individual tallies and averages, you needed the captain to show the way. And that's exactly what Rohit Sharma succeeded in doing. Blessed with a super-abundance of batting talent, the skipper was always ready to risk his wicket to give the team a rapid start. His ultra-aggressive approach could prove frustrating for fans, but it's this attitude that allowed him to play several match-defining innings at the 2024 World Cup. To say the skipper's mindset percolated down to the entire batting unit would be stating the obvious.

No one exemplified India's new batting template better than Virat Kohli. Even though the former captain did not have the kind of tournament he would have desired based on his own impossibly high standards, it took commitment of the highest order to keep in abeyance the art of accumulating runs by the ton even in the most uncertain format of the game and adopt a brand new approach for the sake of the team. It was evidence that the entire batting line-up was on the same page as far as adopting the new batting approach was concerned.